FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Just five months ago, India viewed Bangladesh as one of its foreign policy successes. That changed in August when a popular rebellion ended the 15-year reign of Sheikh Hasina, and the country became a big headache for India. The student-led coup wasn't really a circus of fanaticism. Its leaders, who still advise the interim government and manage the traffic in Dhaka, avow their faith in inclusive democracy. But, without doubt, the upsurge on the streets saw radical infiltration and took a nasty anti-India turn from the start. The revolution carries in its womb the danger of Islamist capture.

The first sign of trouble was that the coup violence did not just target the ruling Awami League's symbols and institutions. Attacks on Hindu homes and properties were reported from the outset. The Hindu Buddhist Christian Unity Council (HBCUC), a minority rights group in Bangladesh, lists 2,010 communal incidents between August 5 and 20, including nine murders, 69 attacks on places of worship and four acts of violence against women. Most of these were directed against the 13 million-strong Hindu community, which accounts for 7.95 per cent of Bangladesh's population. This saw Prime Minister Narendra Modi express his concern to the new interim government headed by Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus, even as he became the first global leader to congratulate him on his appointment. The Yunus government disputes the number of attacks: last week it cited 88 registered cases, and 70 arrests. Whatever the truth, there's no doubt that Bangladesh continues to be volatile and its Hindus live in fear and anxiety. Fresh convulsions marked by sedition charges against former ISKCON monk Chinmoy Krishna Das, who was campaigning for minority safety, illustrate this.



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Leading up to all this was Hasina, who went from being a solution to a problem in her own right. Secular and decidedly pro-India, the Awami League leader had become increasingly repressive and autocratic over the years, which proved to be her undoing. Her affections were spread evenly against all dissidents. Still, special attention was devoted to her primary opponent, the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) of former premier Khaleda Zia, who she even threw in jail. The Awami-BNP acrimony goes back to a founding schism after the 1975 assassination of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the father of Bangladesh. His daughter Hasina inherited the more anti-Pakistan strand, based on linguistic selfhood, which created the nation in 1971; the BNP moved ever closer to Islamist politics, which meant distancing India. In her second premiership in 2001-06, in alliance with the hawkish, pro-Pakistan Jamaat-e-Islami, she tilted towards India's foes, even providing safe harbour to rebel groups from our Northeast.

New Delhi, therefore, saw eminent sense in cultivating Hasina, though, in hindsight, it may have erred in not placing guard rails against her democratic and human rights violations. This is clearer now with the ailing Khaleda's 59-year-old son, Tarique Rahman, all set to return from his exile in London. The BNP's acting chairman is often seen as the uncredited scriptwriter of the coup and the accompanying 'India Out' campaign. The new dispensation has also lifted Hasina's ban on Jamaat. The student leaders are contemplating their own party; many of its coordinators are said to have links with radical Islamists inimical to India.

This week's cover story is from Ground Zero: Special Correspondent Arkamoy Datta Majumdar visits places as far afield as ISKCON's 21-acre Pundarik Dham outside Chittagong and scans the poster-filled walls of Dhaka that decry Indian hegemony. India's unambiguous side-taking has clearly turned it into a villain alongside Hasina. This unwelcome turn confronts New Delhi when it was on the cusp of signing a free trade agreement with Bangladesh. Bilateral trade had nearly doubled since 2017, cresting at $14 billion, over $11 billion of that being in Indian exports. Bangladesh is an unheralded Asian tiger economy of sorts. It had exceeded India and Pakistan's per capita GDP by 2021, reduced its poverty from 80 per cent in 1971 to under 13 per cent, and was set to graduate from the UN's Least Developed Country status in 2024. However, the Covid-19 pandemic badly hit its export-oriented economy; the graph was recovering when it plunged into instability and caught the flu of radical politics. Meanwhile, inflation and joblessness, the bane of post-Covid economies globally, rage unabated. In fact, Hasina's controversial 30 per cent job quota for 1971 'freedom fighters' proved the last straw. By the time she withdrew it in the face of mounting protests, the economic content had already taken on political form.

Alongside the first-hand look, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa pieces together the moving strands of the larger strategic picture. Make no mistake, this may turn out to be an axial point on which the near South Asian future pivots. Those with deep vested interests that may not necessarily coincide with India's include Pakistan, an estranged 'father figure' now back in the reckoning; the US, whose regime change specialists were at hand before the August putsch; and China, always a handy counterweight for those who want to spook India. The concomitant rise of Islamist radicalism in an unsettled and unstable Bangladesh is a cause of worry for India and calls for subtle but vigilant diplomacy. It cannot go at it with a hammer, nor can it shut its eyes and wish it away. Visas and foodgrain exports do give India some leverage but pushing it too hard may make it worse. India has to tread nimbly with its troubled neighbour.

(Aroon Purie)